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INDIAN INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY DELHI
ABU DHABI

History of Psychology & Its Development



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[AHUL261: Introduction to Psychology]

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Today's Learning Objectives

1. Describe the precursors to the establishment of the science of psychology.
2. Identify key individuals and events in the history of psychology.
3. Develop a basic understanding of the processes of scientific development and change.
4. Recognize the role of women, and people of color and those from the global south in the history of psychology.

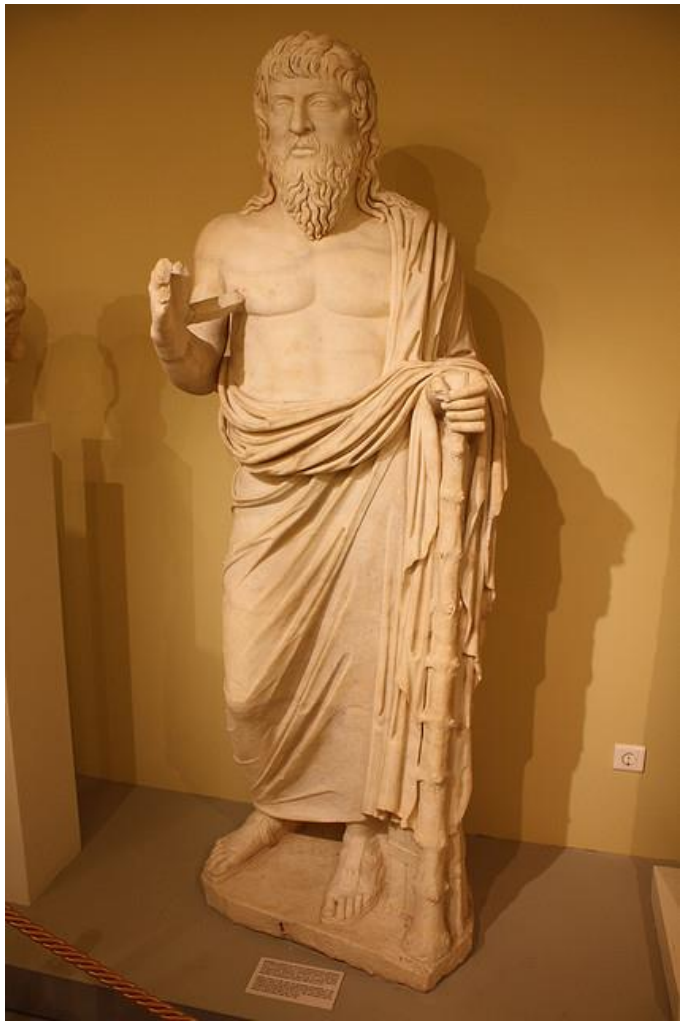
Overview

- **Introduction and Prehistory**
- **19th Century Developments: Physiology & Psychophysics**
- **Schools of Thought in Psychology**
- **Role of Women, People of Color and Global South in development of Psychology**
- **Psychology beyond the Western world**

Introduction and Prehistory

Introduction

- Short history but long past…
- Prehistory
  - Ancient Greek philosophers considered mind to be a suitable topic for scholarly contemplation
  - For hundreds of years, various aspects of mental life were studied by philosophers
  - Psychology as a separate study split from philosophy during mid-19th century

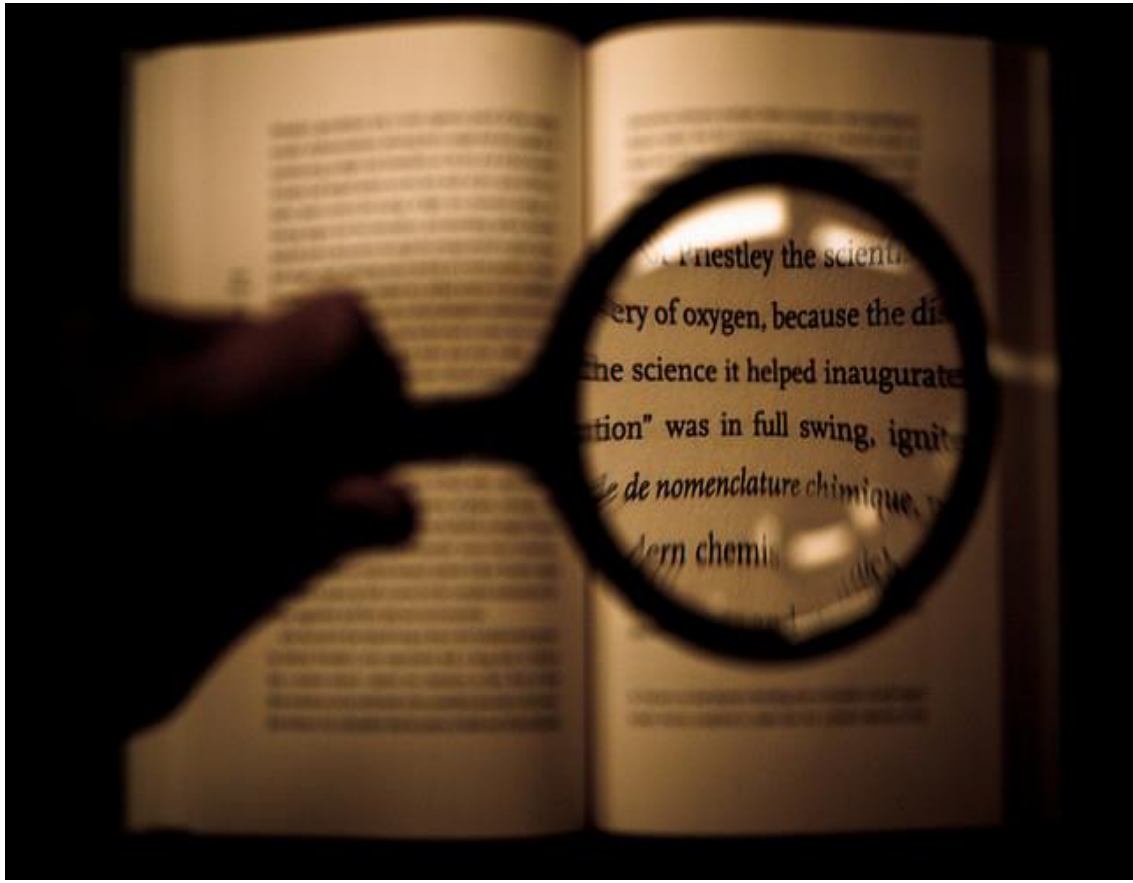


Empiricism

- John Locke (1632-1704) and Thomas Reid (1710-1796) emphasized empiricism, or the primacy of the senses in acquiring knowledge.

- For example, John Locke believed that children were born into the world with minds like "blank slates" (*tabula rasa* in Latin) and that their experiences determined what kind of adults they would become.

- His views contrasted with those of Plato and the 17th-century French philosopher René Descartes, who argued that some knowledge was inborn in humans



Is perception reality?



our senses can, and sometimes do, deceive us.

The Ponzo Illusion: the human mind judges an object's size based on its background.

19th Century Developments

- *Philosophical questions about the nature of mind and knowledge were supplemented in the 19th century by empirical investigations of the sensory systems of the human observer.*

  - **Physiology:**

    Research on nervous activity provided an empirical basis for many human functions that were previously considered functions of the mind.

  - **Psychophysics:**

    Attempted to find the quantitative basis for the mind–body relationship by employing an empirical approach.

  - **Evolution:**

    The writings of Charles Darwin in Britain affirmed a theory of evolution based on the empirical evidence of natural selection.

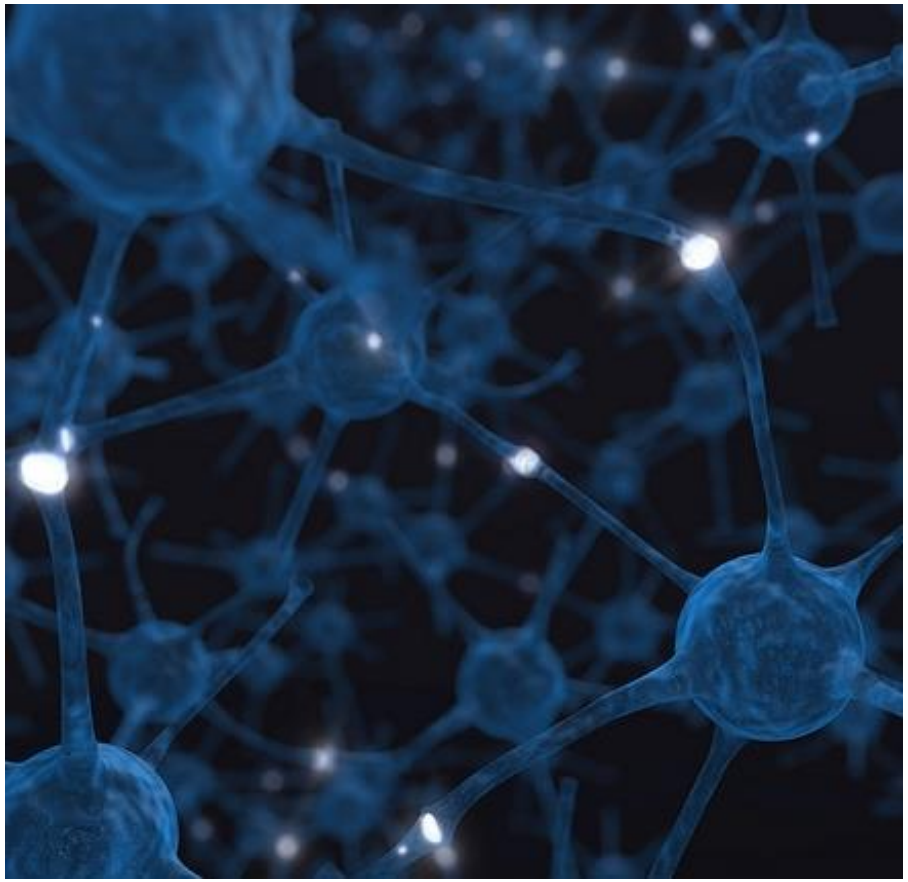
Physiology and Psychophysics

- The study of nervous activity, sensations, and brain physiology confirmed the benefits of careful systematic empirical strategies.

- For psychology, these benefits pointed to the possibility of elucidating the physiological basis of mental operations.

- Hermann von Helmholtz
  - Speed of the neural impulse
  - Senses are fallible but can still be studied

- Weber and Fechner
  - Measured relationships between experience of senses and external reality (psychophysics)



Advances in Physiology of Brain

- Discovery of the neuron, the basic unit of the nervous system – Golgi and Santiago Ramón y Cajal.

- **Phrenology -** interpretation of brain functions - Franz Joseph Gall (1758–1828) and his student J. G. Spurzheim (1776–1832)

- Phrenology attempted to find a physiological localization of mental faculties.

- Phrenology held that the degree of a mental faculty or trait possessed by an individual is determined by the size of the brain area controlling that function and that this can be evaluated by measuring the overlying skull area.

Psychophysics

- *Psychophysics* is a type of sensory physiology that emphasized subjective experience in the study of the relationship between physical stimuli and sensations.

- Psychophysicts were not strictly psychologists but scholars working their own traditional disciplines –physiology, physics, or natural philosophy.

- Studied sensations from several perspectives and emphasized that study of sensations can not be reduced to physiology or physics.

- Considered sensations as a reflection of the mind–body problem, rather than as a situation for anatomical and physical study alone.

Schools of Thought in Psychology

Schools of Thought in Psychology

- From mid-19th century onwards, psychology came to hold different views about the nature of the mind and the best way to study it.

- About the same time, fundamental questions were raised about the definition, nature and scope of psychology giving birth to different *schools of thoughts in psychology*.

Structuralism



Wilhelm Wundt

Structuralism is a school of thought in Psychology that stresses the basic units of experience and combinations in which they occur.

<u>Wilhelm Wundt:</u>

- Physiologist and Philosopher. So called 'Father of psychology'
- Founded the first experimental psychology laboratory in 1879—Leipzig Lab.
- Argued that the mind must be studied objectively and scientifically.
- Main concern was with techniques used for uncovering natural laws of the human mind—*he was in search for the basic unit of thought.*

Structuralism—contd.

- Titchener: Viewed that human conscious experience could be understood by breaking it down into components



Edward Titchener

Approach:

- Train subjects in introspection and reporting techniques
- INTROSPECTION: looking inside oneself and try to describe what's going on—understanding oneself.
- Trained observers introspected and reported what they experienced
- Try to formulate general theories based on their subjects' reports.

Functionalism

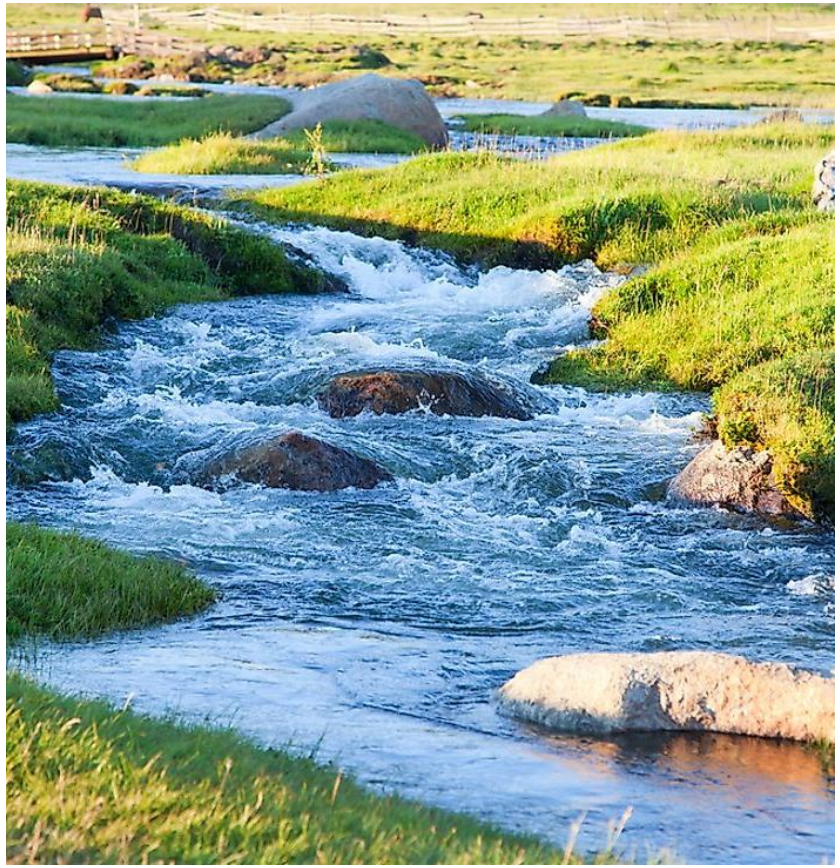


William James

- William James' (1842-1910) seminal book *Principles of Psychology* asserted consciousness should be studied as a continuous whole
- Combined his studies of physiology and philosophy to create psychology
- Proposed *Functionalism* (what the mind does) as an alternative to *structuralism* (how mind is structured)

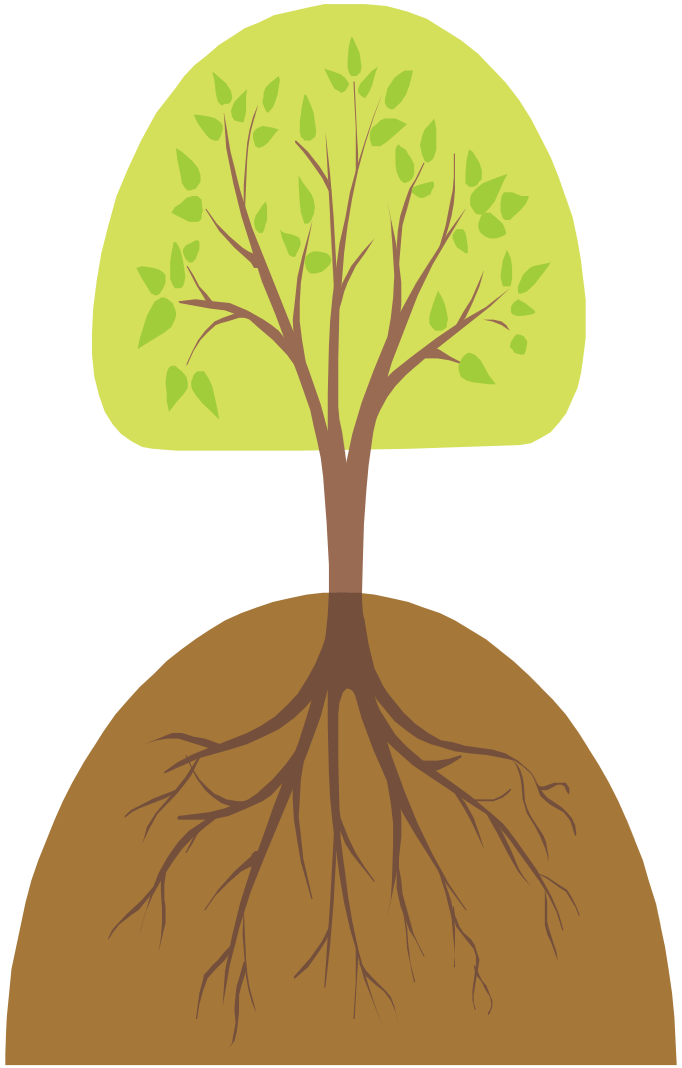
The Stream of Consciousness

The first and foremost concrete fact which every one will affirm to belong to his inner experience is the fact that ***consciousness of some sort goes on***. ***'States of mind' succeed each other*** *in him*. If we could say in English 'it thinks,' as we say 'it rains' or 'it blows,' we should be stating the fact most simply and with the minimum of assumption. As we cannot, we must simply say that ***thought goes on*** (James, 1892).



Gestalt

- School of Psychology that studies how people perceive and experience objects as whole patterns
- Max Wertheimer, Kurt Koffka, Wolfgang Kohler
- **"The whole is different from the sum of its parts"**
- Mental experience depends on patterning and organizing different elements. Example: *When we see a tree, we see just that, a tree, not a series of branches.*



Psychoanalysis

- Freud – An Austrian neurologist
- Freud is credited with many concepts (e.g., unconscious mind) that influenced 20th century thinkers in psychology and beyond.
- In his clinical practice, Freud encountered patients suffering from nervous disorders. Their complaints could not be explained in terms of purely physical causes.



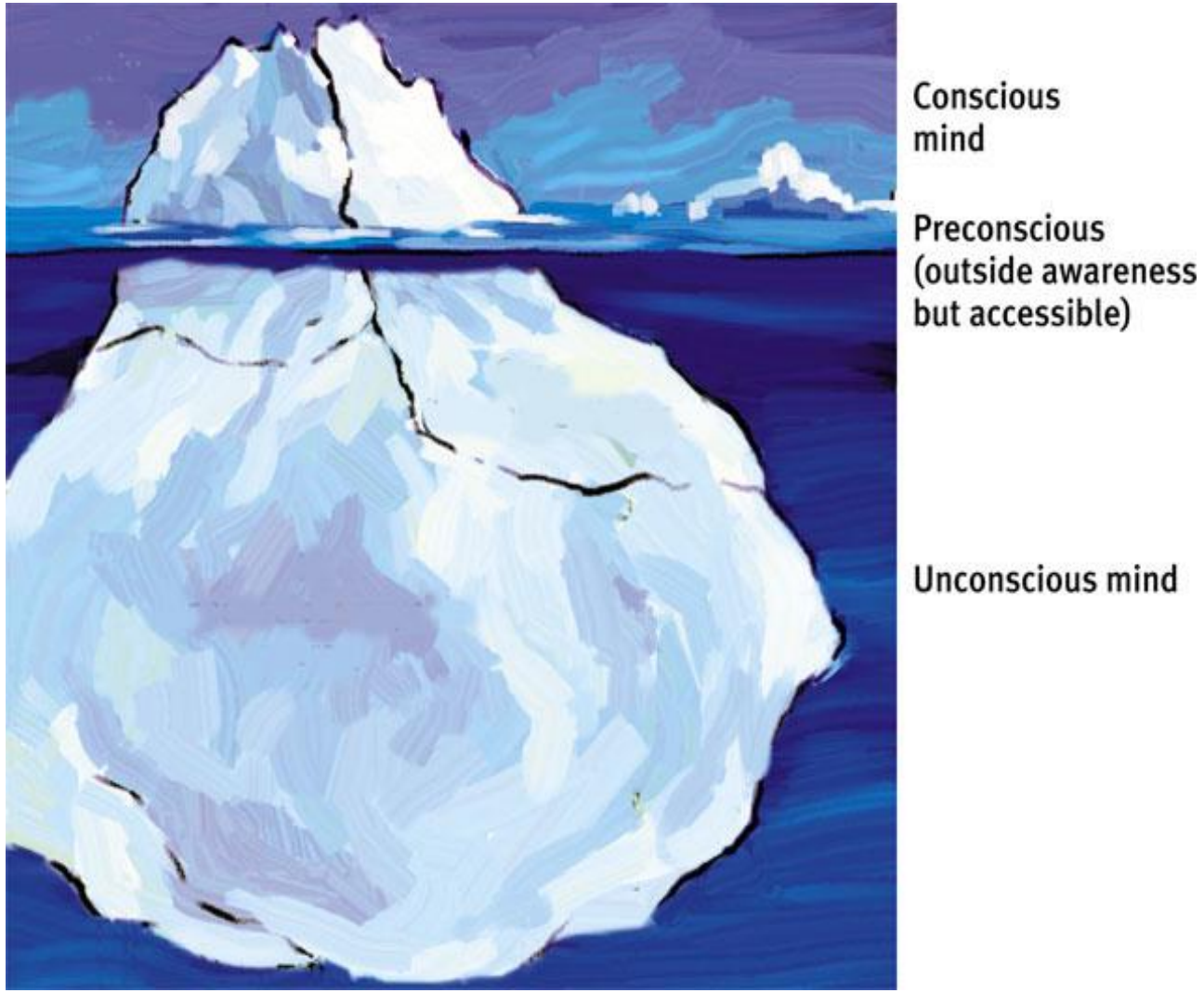
Sigmund Freud
(1856-1939)

Culver Pictures

Discovery of the unconscious mind

- The mind is like an iceberg. It is mostly hidden, and below the surface lies the unconscious mind. The preconscious stores temporary memories.

- Unconscious mind is a reservoir of mostly unacceptable thoughts, wishes, feelings, and memories.



Behaviorism

- Behaviorists like B.F. Skinner (1904-1990) and John Watson (1878-1958) focused on what was observable and measurable and rejected the idea is that mind could be studied (or worth the effort)

- The emphasis was on rigorous experimental investigation of overt human and animal behavior.

- Ultimate goal was finding a relevant **S-R relationship** and use it for prediction and control of behavior



James B. Watson

"Give me a dozen healthy infants, well-formed, and my own special world to bring them up in and I'll guarantee to take any one at random and train him to be any type of specialist I might select – a doctor, a lawyer, artist…"

- Watson 1924

Cognitive Revolution

- Behaviorism's emphasis on objectivity and focus on external behavior had obscured the study of mind.



- By the 1950s, new disciplinary perspectives in linguistics, neuroscience, and computer science were emerging, and these areas revived interest in the mind as a focus of scientific inquiry. This later led to formation of cognitive science.

- In the 1960's, psychologists eschewed behaviorist focus and adopted cognitive approach.

- Cognitive approach emphasized that mental processes such as language, memory, and problem solving should play a larger role in understanding human behavior.

Schools of Thought in Psychology at a Glance



Structuralism

Breaks conscious experience into basic sensations, images, and feelings.



Functionalism

Explains mental life by the adaptive purposes it serves in everyday living.



Gestalt

Shows that perception is organized into meaningful wholes rather than isolated parts.



Psychoanalytic

Emphasizes unconscious conflict, early early relationships, and symbolic meaning.



Behaviorism

Restricts psychology to observable behavior shaped by learning and environment.



Cognitivism

Treats the mind as an active processor of information, memory, attention, and problem solving.

Role of Women and People of Color

Women in psychology: Founding mothers

- Leta Stetter Hollingworth
  - Child development and women's issues
- Mary Calkins
  - First female president of the APA (American Psychological Association)
- Karen Horney
  - Social and cultural aspects of personality

Psychology and Society



- Psychologists have used science to impact social change

- In 1936 the Society for the Psychological Study of Social Issues (SPSSI) was formed in the US.

Psychology's Controvertial Past in US

- Historically, Psychologists have taken **racist positions** and used science to defend racism, eugenic movement (Kamin, 1974).

- **Supported status-quo:** Offered solutions to human predicaments, almost exclusively, in terms of the self-adjustment, leaving the social order conveniently unaffected (Fanon, 1967; Richards, 2003).

- Recently American Psychological Association (APA) 'apologized' for promoting, perpetuating and **failing to challenge racism, racial discrimination, and human hierarchy**.



Psychology's contribution to Civil Rights Movement

- The work of African American psychologists Mamie Phipps Clark and her Husband Kenneth Clark helped to show how segregation negatively impacts the self-esteem of African American children.

- This research had impact on the 1954 Brown v. Board of Education ruling that ended school segregation in United States



Psychologists and civil rights activists Mamie and Kenneth Clark.

Psychology in the Global South

Psychology in India

- **Rich Heritage**

- **More than 100 years of history**: The first psychological laboratory in India was established in Calcutta University in 1916. Subsequently Psychology departments were also established in Mysore in 1924, and Patna in 1946 (Sinha, 2017).

- **Links with Leading Psychologists in the world**: Girindra Shekhar Bose, Chairman of the Calcutta University Department of Psychology in 1920s, was closely associated with Sigmund Freud and became a pioneer of psychoanalysis in India.

- **Many Indians held chairs in world class departments of Psychology around the world –** Mahzarin Banaji (Harvard); Anand Pranjpe (Simon Fraser), J P Das (Alberta), etc.



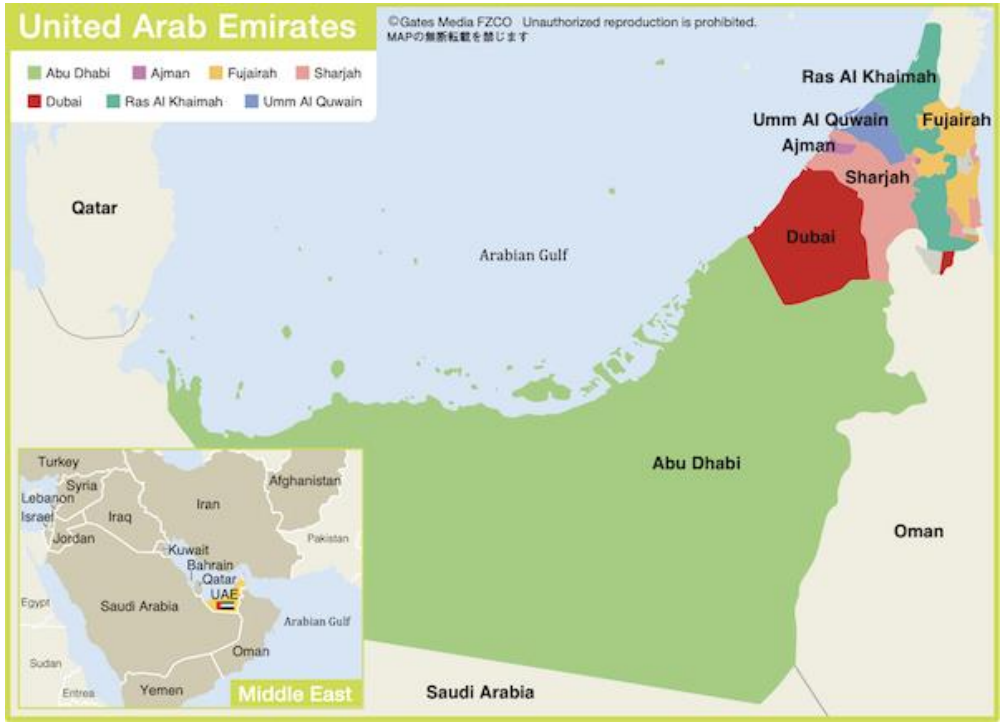
Psychology in the Middle East

- Rich Heritage
- *Ilm al-Nafs* - “the science/study of the **nafs**.”
- Depending on the context, **nafs** may refer to the self, soul, person, or psyche; no single English translation is fully adequate.
- Classical scholarship addressed cognition, emotion, bodily health, moral character, habit, suffering, and self-transformation. These discussions appeared across philosophy, medicine, ethics, theology, and Sufi traditions.
- Modern scientific psychology began to develop first in Egypt and, to a lesser extent, Lebanon, during the early to mid-twentieth century.
- Egypt and Lebanon became important regional centres for psychology teaching, research, and mental-health services.



Psychology in the UAE

- Psychology entered many other Arab countries from the 1960s onward.
- In the UAE, psychology expanded alongside the country's rapid development after federation in 1971.
- Psychology was established as a separate discipline at UAE University in 1971, initially taught in Arabic within the Faculty of Education before later moving to the social-science context; clinical psychology and postgraduate training developed subsequently.
- Psychology in the Middle East and UAE is not simply "Western psychology applied locally."
- It is an evolving field shaped by regional intellectual traditions, colonial and educational histories, and contemporary efforts to build culturally relevant research and practice.



Key Takeaways

- Psychology has a long past but a relatively short history as a separate scientific discipline
- New ways of studying human experience empirically, especially through physiology, psychophysics, and measurement shaped emergence of psychology as a discipline
- Psychology has never been one unified perspective: structuralism, functionalism, Gestalt psychology, psychoanalysis, behaviourism, and cognitivism asked different questions and used different methods
- Scientific approaches are valuable, but they are also shaped by historical assumptions about whose experiences count, what is considered “normal,” and which social problems deserve attention.
- The discipline has developed globally: India, the Middle East, and the UAE have their own intellectual traditions, institutional histories, and current efforts to make psychology more culturally relevant.



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